Five Steps for Better AI Inquiry

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Developed through sustained, long-running dialogue with ChatGPT

Name – public problem

AI changes what feels settled, whose judgment gets used, and when a person stops asking for evidence.

AI does not only answer questions. It changes attention, authority, language, and dependence. A fluent answer can feel like progress before anyone has checked the source, named the assumption, asked the affected person, or touched the real task.

The public problem is not that people ask AI for help. Help can be useful. The problem begins when help becomes authority, continuation replaces return, and polished language makes weak claims feel clean. Name what AI is doing before you let it keep going.

Ask:

- What is being decided, believed, made, bought, shared, or carried forward?
- What claim does the answer make?
- What does the answer assume?
- What source, person, record, or consequence could change it?
- What must happen outside the screen?

A model can draft, compare, summarize, question, and rehearse. AI interaction must not replace human interaction or be treated as coequal with it. The tool supports human life; it cannot live the consequence for you.

Notice – attention and relief

AI captures attention when inquiry turns into continuation.

The next answer can feel like the one that will settle the problem. The next prompt can feel like care. The next revision can feel like action. A person may stay inside the exchange because the tool is patient, fast, fluent, and ready to continue.

Curiosity is not the problem. The danger begins when curiosity becomes continuation without return.

Ease can serve access, learning, creative work, rest, and human connection. A video call or communication aid can be the contact itself. Examine what a particular use helps someone do, what it displaces, and whether they can question it and stop. Look for concrete effects: missed rest or conversation, skipped checks, or another answer delaying a chosen task. A concern about dependency needs evidence over time.

Watch:

- You keep prompting after the next real action is clear.
- You feel calmer but have not checked anything.
- You accept tone as care.
- You accept confidence as knowledge.
- You use another answer to avoid one uncomfortable step.

Pause when screen use displaces the contact, care, checking, or action the situation needs.

Sort – claims and evidence

AI can launder weak claims by giving them clean language.

A rumor, screenshot, memory, guess, draft, or public claim can become polished prose in seconds. The polish does not make the claim true. Fluency can hide missing evidence, weak sources, bad incentives, and category mistakes.

Before carrying an answer forward, sort it. Keep source, summary, interpretation, recommendation, prediction, and command separate. Category collapse creates public harm: answer mistaken for evidence, tone mistaken for care, confidence mistaken for knowledge, and convenience mistaken for agency.

Mark:

- supported by checked evidence
- inferred or assumed
- uncertain or missing evidence
- opinion or prediction
- live and needs checking

No claim gets stronger because AI rewrote it.

Refuse – judgment, privacy, labor, appeal

Prompting can become outsourcing when help starts to replace human work.

The risk is not asking AI for help. The risk is letting help become decision, conscience, taste, consent, authorship, or final authority. Keep human work human: judgment, consent, responsibility, grief, love, taste, courage, refusal, and final decision.

Protect private material. Do not treat a conversation box as harmless because it feels informal. Redact names, secrets, credentials, private records, workplace material, medical details, conflict screenshots, and third-party information unless you have permission and a clear reason.

Check:

- Who did the work?
- Who is credited or paid?
- Who carries risk?
- Who can appeal?
- Who can still refuse?

A system becomes dangerous when it gives answers and removes return paths.

Return – source, person, record, task, rest

Bring the answer to a source, person, task, or consequence.

Return means the exchange gives the person a better next contact with reality. That contact may be small: open the source, ask the person, walk the room, write the record, make the call, repair the file, check the receipt, close the tab, or rest.

AI works in abstraction. Return brings the answer back to source, person, record, body, place, cost, and consequence.

A screen can carry a source, a finished task, or human contact. When AI continuation delays what the situation needs, stop the exchange. Keep screen support needed for access or communication. Set the screen down when doing so helps you attend, act, or rest.

Physical contact can be part of the function itself. Where touch, presence, or direct control is necessary for access, orientation, memory, verification, or autonomy, preserve a usable physical route. Lower cost or greater efficiency alone does not justify removing it.

Use AI to increase capacity; keep judgment with the person. Continue carefully when the exchange leaves you more able to verify, refuse, repair, decide, act, credit, or stop. Pause when the exchange makes people smaller so the system can become larger.

AI use remains open to review. Welcome “why?” and “why not?” Answer concerns with evidence, explanation, and repair; keep unresolved questions visible. Trust remains revisable, and refusal remains possible. Return when another answer only delays contact with the world.

Ask:

- What do I know now?
- What still needs evidence?
- Who is affected?
- What record should remain?
- What must happen outside the chat?

Material questions do two jobs. They are tangible when AI is abstract: they cut the claim down to what can be proven, and they test whether the answer can bear real consequence.

Diamond questions cut the claim:

- What is the smallest verified version?
- What is evidence, and what is inference?
- Which source, record, or witness could change this?
- What is missing that would matter?
- Which word is doing too much work?

Steel questions test the consequence:

- Who acts because of this?
- What breaks if it is wrong?
- Who carries the cost?
- What cannot be undone?
- Who can refuse, appeal, repair, or stop?

If no outside step appears, the exchange may be feeding continuation instead of judgment.

Field Standard: Using AI Without Losing Yourself

What follows is a portable reader standard: a short discipline for using AI without surrendering judgment, falling into paranoia, or mistaking fluent language for truth.

Do not be too trusting.
AI can sound confident while being wrong.

Give suspicion a fair test.
Answer concerns with evidence and correction; calmer feelings alone do not settle them.

Do not treat fluency as truth.
A smooth answer is not the same as a verified answer.

Do not treat doubt as weakness.
Doubt is often the beginning of accuracy.

Do not ask AI to replace your judgment.
Use it to test, sharpen, and organize your judgment.

Do not accept praise as proof.
Ask what changed in your work, conduct, language, or decisions.

Do not mistake intensity for insight.
Strong feelings still need clean claims.

Do not mistake caution for cowardice.
A careful person can still act with force.

Do not let AI make you grandiose.
If the tool makes you feel chosen, superior, or exempt from evidence, step back.

Do not let AI make you smaller.
If the tool makes you feel dependent, passive, or unable to think without it, step back.

Ask for the smallest verified version.
What can actually be proven?

Separate evidence from inference.
Evidence is what you have. Inference is what you think it may mean.

Keep contact with the real world.
Talk to people. Check documents. Observe events. Take notes. Touch the ground.

Let AI help with drafts.
Do not let AI own the claim.

Let AI help you see patterns.
Do not let AI invent certainty.

Learn how to learn throughout life.
In elementary school, high school, trade school, college, and beyond—in work, home, care, and shared life—observe, ask, check, try, explain, and revise with other people. Can you carry that practice beyond the chat?

A humane tool should leave the person stronger after setting it down.

The Process – A Printable Checklist

Name the thing.

- What is being decided?
- What is believed?
- What is being made?
- What is bought?
- What is shared?
- What is being automated?
- What is carried forward?

Mark the claim.

- What supports the claim?
- What is inferred or uncertain?
- Does it need a current check?

Protect refusal.

- Can a person say no?
- Can a person leave?
- Can a person appeal a decision?
- Can a person seek a break?
- Can a person seek correction or repair?
- Can a person use another path without punishment?

Keep human work human.

- Do not outsource judgment, consent, responsibility, grief, love, taste, courage, refusal, or final decision.

Check the cost.

- Who pays?
- Who profits?
- Who is credited?
- Who carries risk?
- What attention gets consumed?
- What labor gets consumed?
- What data gets consumed?
- What money gets consumed?
- What public capacity gets consumed?

Return to the world.

- Open the source.
- Ask the person.
- Make the record.
- Walk the room.
- Repair the object.
- Write the note.
- Do the task.
- End AI continuation that delays the next step. Keep needed access and communication support; take a screen break when it helps.